Cumulative Reflection

I entered the Computer Engineering program at Iowa State in the fall of 2023, which was the start of my college career. I was new to campus and had some ideas about what college might be like. Growing up, college had always felt like a logical and expected next step, and I hoped it would let me change and grow into a different person than I was in high school. At the time, I thought change would come from the classes I took and what I learned. The early classes all felt disconnected, but looking back, I realize that they were also opportunities to connect with and learn from the people around me. My connections with my peers have been one of the most important parts of my time at Iowa State.

As I went through my classes and looked toward the future of what I would be learning and focusing my career around, I began to feel that I wasn't going in the right direction. After my first full year, I changed majors during my sophomore year to become a Cybersecurity student. I felt a deeper connection to the technical aspects of computers, but I didn't have the same connection to electronics or coding that I had expected when I first chose Computer Engineering. Changing majors was a difficult decision, but it allowed me to pursue something that felt more natural to me. I felt disconnected from the idea of designing circuits or spending hours coding. Once I made the switch, I was just in time to start my early cybersecurity courses, where I realized that this was the focus I wanted to have. Throughout my college career, I have had to complete many coding projects, but I have come to see them less as an end goal and more as opportunities to understand the underlying systems and techniques that I will need in my future career.

Through my later courses, I refined my focus and grew as a person and as a student. Growth never feels the way you think it will. I expected college to change me in some obvious or dramatic way,

but most of the changes happened through small experiences that seemed insignificant at the time. Doing better in my classes, becoming more comfortable putting myself into social situations, and becoming more willing to try things outside of my comfort zone all happened gradually. Whether it was a comment from a teacher, a difficult lab, or a good interaction when talking to someone new, each experience taught me something. I have also grown to enjoy my lab tasks and become interested in the new information they teach, even though freshman me had to be dragged to each one. Looking back, I believe that change is one of the most important things I have gained from college. I did not suddenly become a different person. Instead, I became a slightly better version of myself through the experiences I had every day.

Now, working on my senior design project with a team of Cybersecurity majors, I have the opportunity to work on a project alongside a team of students, a faculty advisor, and a company. Senior design has given me another opportunity to learn how to effectively work with a team on a large, overarching project. It has also shown me a side of engineering that I could not fully experience through individual assignments and exams. Having to communicate with teammates, meet expectations, solve problems together, and work toward a larger goal has given me insight into professional responsibilities and what working with companies like this may be like. More importantly, it has shown me how much of a professional's education happens through working with other people.

I regret not being more involved in learning activities outside of class. I was a member of some clubs, like the Cybersecurity Club and Ski Club, but I never found a club or group that I really connected with. At first, I saw that as something I had missed out on. However, my time in the clubs I did attend taught me that even if you haven't found your true group of people, there are still opportunities to connect with others everywhere. Some of the most meaningful parts of college have come from conversations and relationships that I never expected to have. I have learned almost as much from the people I have met and the connections I have made here as I have from the information I learned in my

classes. Because of that, I understand now that learning isn't just about comprehending material. It is also about becoming a better person, understanding yourself, and growing in all aspects of your life.

As my time as a student at Iowa State comes to an end, I look back and reflect on what I could have done and what I should have done. I would do many things differently, and there are also things I would keep exactly as they are. I regret some of the opportunities I didn't take, but I don't regret the people I have met and become close with along the way. When I first came to Iowa State, I thought college would be about learning the skills I needed for a career and becoming a different person. Now, as I approach the end of that experience, I realize that it was much more about the process of becoming who I am. The classes, labs, clubs, mistakes, friendships, and challenges all played a part in that process. I hope that I can continue to make the most of my last year here, make some more lifelong memories, and learn some more lifelong lessons.